jobs and educational institutions.

With Bihar on the cusp of its assembly election, Tejaswi is acutely aware that he cannot allow Nitish to dominate the political discourse unchallenged. The incumbent's 'Rojgar Matlab Nitish Sarkar' (Employment Means Nitish Government) narrative has gained traction and, unless disrupted, it threatens to overshadow Tejaswi's own promises. Back in 2020, his pledge of one million government jobs propelled the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) to the single largest party status in the assembly, enabling it to secure 75 of the 243 seats. Five years later, Nitish has not only appropriated this promise but has amplified its execution, claiming that over 900,000 appointments have been made under his administration. The March 9 event was the latest spectacle in this ongoing political theatre.



ANI

▲ **JOB PUSH** Nitish Kumar handing out an appointment letter in Patna, Mar. 9

QUOTA OFFENSIVE

- **Nitish Kumar claims 900,000 appointments during his tenure; Tejaswi accuses him of quota theft**
- **51,000 teachers recruited by Nitish administration, but Tejaswi alleges loss of reservations**
- **RJD vows legal, political fight to restore 65 per cent reservations**
- **Tejaswi reframes Lalu's legacy as social transformation, not misrule, seeking to neutralise the NDA's time-worn strategy**

Tejaswi has reframed the debate, arguing that the jobs being handed out are being carved out of the OBC and EBC quota that was promised but never delivered. At the heart of his argument lies the Bihar government's November 2023 decision to increase reservations for Scheduled Castes (SCs), Scheduled Tribes (STs) and OBCs from 50 per cent to 65 per cent. At the time, Tejaswi was serving as deputy chief minister in the Nitish-led government and had played a role in pushing this policy forward.

However, the political landscape shifted in January 2024 when Nitish abruptly severed ties with the RJD, Congress and Left parties to realign with the NDA. The move proved electorally beneficial—the Janata Dal (United) secured 12 of the 16 Lok Sabha seats it contested. But it also contributed to a legal and political quagmire. In June 2024, the Patna High Court struck down the 65 per cent reservation move, deeming it unconstitutional for exceeding the Supreme Court's 50 per cent cap. The apex court also declined to stay the verdict, dealing a major blow to the Nitish administration.

In a state as caste-conscious as Bihar, Tejaswi has seized upon this constraint on reservations to erode Nitish's standing. His appeal is calculated: he is actively courting Bihar's most decisive electoral demographic—the OBCs and EBCs—who together make up over 63 per cent of the state's 130 million residents. The recent caste survey confirmed their overwhelming numerical dominance, with EBCs accounting for 36.01 per cent and OBCs for 27.12 per cent of the population. If Tejaswi can stoke their discontent, he hopes to fundamentally reshape the electoral landscape.

On March 9, as part of this game plan, Tejaswi demanded the restoration of the 65 per cent quota. Standing before a sea of party loyalists outside the RJD headquarters, he thundered: "Because of this government's theft of reservation, approximately 50,000 jobs have been snatched away from the people." The controversy surrounding the 65 per cent quota has simmered since last year, with the Patna High Court's ruling. Now, with the matter pending before the apex court, the RJD has vowed to challenge it in both the legislature and the judiciary. "We are monitoring the proceedings meticulously through our advocates. We shall not permit reservations to be dismantled—this is our commitment and our pledge," Tejaswi declared.

Yet, the RJD leader's strategy is about more than just reservations. His decision to embrace the RJD's legacy rather than distance himself from it signals a newfound clarity in his political approach. For nearly two decades, the Nitish-BJP alliance has relied on a simple electoral argument—to the